

Class Exercise 4: Humble and apologetic? Predicting apology quality with intellectual and general humility

Instructions: **Read** our base paper (Ludwig et al., 2022) and **answer** prompt questions

Please submit your CEs as a Word document.

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Introduction Section

- 1) In your own words, why do you think conflict resolution is an important topic for psychological research? What role do apologies play in resolving interpersonal conflict?

Conflict resolution is an important topic for psychological research because of how much of a role it plays in our relationships. Unresolved conflict slowly builds resentment, which creates an unhealthy relationship dynamic.

Apologizing is the only true way to resolve conflict. If a person accepts a sincere apology, there will no longer be resentment. If the apology is not accepted, then the relationship will most likely end, which still prevents an unhealthy dynamic forming.

In Section 1.2 (p. 2), the authors discuss barriers to apologizing.
How might intellectual humility weaken these barriers (see also Section 1.3 on p 5)?

Intellectual humility involves empathy. This means that someone with intellectual humility will most likely already understand that these barriers exist and can address them if they arise.

Study 1 Method (note that the methods are very similar across the two studies)

- 2) How did the researchers operationalize intellectual humility?

The participants of the study completed a self-reported scale called the “General intellectual humility scale”.

What were the dependent variables (i.e., the outcomes they were trying to predict), and how were they operationalized?

The dependent variables were apology comprehensiveness, defensiveness, and inaction. They were all operationalized using self-reported responses to each of the apology elements.

In each study, participants imagined themselves in a hypothetical transgression. Can you think of one strength and one limitation of using a hypothetical transgression compared to using a real-life transgression?

An obvious limitation of using a hypothetical transgression is that the true emotions and stakes that come with a real transgression will not be present. However, the hypothetical nature of the study means that the elements of the offense will be held constant across all the participants.

Study 2 Results

- 3) Regarding the findings in Study 2, describe the correlation between intellectual humility and the dependent variables the researchers were trying to predict. For example: Was intellectual humility positively or negatively correlated with each dependent variable?

There was a significant correlation between intellectual humility and each dependent variable.

Participants that were higher in intellectual humility were more likely to offer a high-quality and comprehensive apology. In contrast, they were less likely to engage in defensive behavior as well as inaction.

- 4) On p 10, the researchers state that one “*limitation is that the cross-sectional, **correlational** nature of the data does not allow for causal interpretations of either the associations with the outcomes or the indirect effects.*”

This is a limitation because the researchers operationalized intellectual humility as a participant variable—in other words, they measured intellectual humility and examined whether it was correlated with apology behavior. Because the study is correlational, it is also possible that apologizing increases intellectual humility. It is impossible to rule out this reverse causal path using correlational methods. Therefore, our goal in this class is to operationalize intellectual humility as a true IV because this will get us closer to the idea that intellectual humility can increase apology behavior rather than the other way around.

To do that, we are going to attempt to experimentally manipulate intellectual humility. For example, we will randomly assign participants to either an intellectual humility condition or a

comparison condition (e.g., a control condition).

In the intellectual humility condition, what exercise, activity, or instructions could we provide participants to boost their feelings of intellectual humility — at least temporarily — during a 10-minute study?

Your idea does not have to be perfect. As a researcher, try to think about how you might increase intellectual humility, at least momentarily.

Because intellectual humility greatly increases one's ability to admit being wrong, perhaps an exercise where each participant must think of a time when they admitted being wrong (or at least realized that they were wrong) would momentarily increase their intellectual humility.